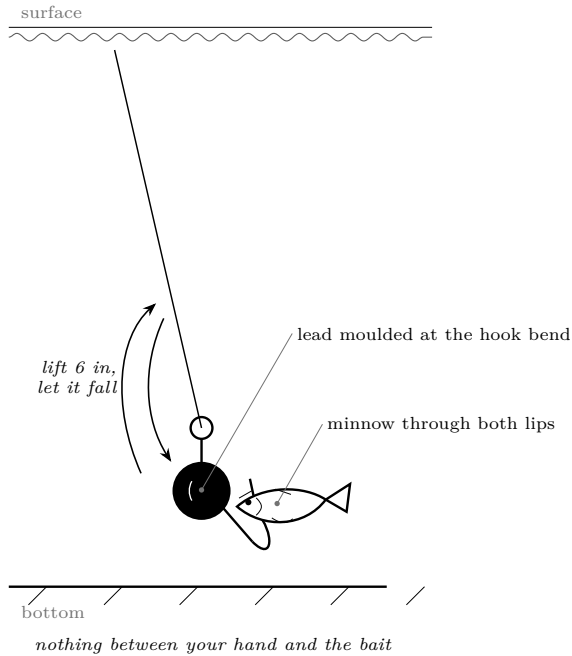


Jig and Minnow

One hook, one weight, one piece of bait

The simplest way to put a bait exactly where a walleye is



What it does	Weight and hook in one piece, so you feel everything and control the depth absolutely. There is nothing between your hand and the bait.
Why it matters	In cold water a walleye's take is a barely perceptible change in weight. A jig transmits that; almost nothing else does.
Weight	1/8 oz to 15 ft, 1/4 oz to 25 ft, 3/8 oz deeper or in wind. Use the lightest head that still lets you feel bottom.
Head shape	Round for vertical work; a stand-up head for dragging on a clean bottom.
Bait	A 2-3 in fathead or shiner hooked up through both lips. A half crawler or a leech works in warmer water.
Line	6-8 lb. Braid with a fluorocarbon leader if you want maximum feel in deep water.

Fish it

1. Lower or cast, and let it fall on a **semi-tight** line. Watch and feel — a good share of bites happen on the initial drop, and on a fully slack line you will never know.
2. When it hits bottom, lift the rod tip about six inches and **let it fall back under control**, following it down with the rod. The fall is the presentation. The lift only sets up the next fall.
3. Pause on the bottom for a two-count. Repeat.
4. If you are casting, work the jig back with the same lift-and-fall while the boat holds on the contour.

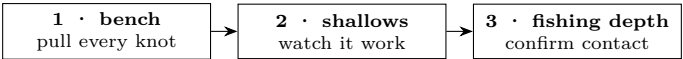
Reading the bite

The classic take	You lift and the jig feels <i>heavy</i> — as though you picked up a wet leaf. That is a walleye. Sweep the rod immediately.
The tick	A single sharp tap on the fall. Set at once.
Nothing	Sometimes the jig simply stops falling early. Set.
Do not snap	A firm upward sweep sets a single sharp hook. A violent snap tears it out of a soft mouth.
Stay vertical	Keep the line as close to straight up and down as the drift allows. Line at an angle costs you feel and costs you hooksets.
Where	Pine spots 2, 3, 4 and 8 ; North spots 2, 3 and 4 . 15-35 ft.

When to use it

Cold water — ice-out through May, and again from October on — and any time you can see fish on electronics and want to put something on their heads. It is also the best rig for teaching feel, because everything that happens to the jig arrives in your hand.

Prove the rig



- Bench test

Pull the knot hard, align it at the top of the jig eye, and confirm the minnow lies straight rather than corkscrewed.
- Water test

Drop in clear water: the jig falls head-first and the minnow tracks without spinning.
- Proof at depth

You can name each bottom contact; if not, step from 1/8 to 1/4 oz before changing cadence.
- If it fails

Snagging constantly: hold the rod higher and shorten hops. No bottom signal: remove line bow or add one weight step. Change one variable, repeat the same cast or drop, and keep the first setting that restores the expected proof.

Record the adjustment

Try	Depth / distance	Sink count	Observed action	Fish response	Next single change
1					
2					
3					

Questions before another cast

Did the rig reach the intended depth? What visible line, rod-tip, bottom, or lure response proves that? Did the connection and hook point survive the retrieve? Was a follow, bite, snag, or refusal observed rather than assumed? Name one variable to change and one to hold constant. If the observation cannot answer those questions, repeat the same short controlled cast before changing the setup.

☐ Sketch the cast: surface, cover, target depth, line angle, and where the response occurred

Evidence-based verdict

☐ repeat unchanged

☐ alter one variable

☐ retire or repair the rig

Reason and next prediction

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